

Breaking down India's victory

Pranay Rajiv

pranay.rajiv@thehindu.co.in

Only a very brave man would have bet against India going into the Champions Trophy 2025 final against New Zealand. In fact, many projected the Men in Blue to steamroll the Kiwis to secure a second ICC title in as many years. However, New Zealand displayed fortitude to push the game deep, forcing India

into several nervy moments, before eventually succumbing to defeat. No team pushed India farther away from victory in the tournament than what the Black Caps did in Dubai in the final.

Here are four major plot points which determined the fate of the high-intensity final:

India secured the Champions Trophy with a hard-fought win over New Zealand. Key moments, including early aggression and tactical bowling shifts, defined a final where **momentum swung sharply.**



ROHIT SHARMA'S POWERPLAY CHARGE

Heading into the run-chase, India knew its fate hinged heavily on a quick start, considering the potential impact New Zealand spinners were to have later in the innings.

India had the right ingredient to do that — skipper Rohit Sharma. Since the start of 2023, no one has scored more runs in the opening PowerPlay in ODIs than him. His strike rate of 122.56 in this phase is better than any batter with at least 500 runs.

Rohit stamped his authority in the final by wading into a depleted New Zealand pace attack, which was missing an injured Matt Henry. Eight of Rohit's 10 boundaries came against the Kiwi quicks as he lifted India to 64/0 in the first 10 overs.

Expectedly, New Zealand's spinners took over in the middle overs, conceding just 3.55 runs per over, bettering their Indian counterparts (4.25). But India managed to negate that through Rohit's charge on the Kiwi quicks, who leaked 8.33 RPO, compared to Indian pacers' 6.92 RPO.